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Centering Anti-Racism in Social Work Education: Integration of Critical Race Theory Across an MSW Curriculum

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Abstract

Ranging from a multicultural approach to models of cultural sensitivity and cultural competency, social work education has historically avoided challenging the power of racism in shaping inequity in the United States. We argue that integrating critical race theory (CRT) in social work education decenters whiteness, counters color-evasive racism in education, and centers anti-racist ideas and practices. CRT provides social work educators with a framework that explicitly addresses race and racism while challenging social work students to self-reflect critically on their own experiences with privilege and oppression. Further, it enables social work students and practitioners to analyze race and other systems of oppression structurally. This manuscript offers an overview of how CRT is integrated across an MSW curriculum to better prepare social work students to engage in anti-racist social work practice. We describe specific examples of how CRT is infused into the curriculum in theory and practice courses. We conclude with an acknowledgment that CRT is not without limitations and call for more empirical research that assesses the effectiveness of CRT's application to social work praxis.

Keywords: anti-oppressive education, anti-racism, race, racism

The murders of Ahmaud Arbery, Breonna Taylor, and George Floyd in the first half of 2020 forced another major reckoning on the centuries of violence against Black people in the United States (U.S.). The U.S., as a settler-colonial society, was founded on anti-Indigenous and anti-Black racism. More than a historic epoch, settler colonialism is an ongoing societal structure that shapes all aspects of the contemporary racialized social order to maintain the dominance of White settlers (McKay et al., 2020; Rowe & Tuck, 2017). Incorporating a settler colonial framework into the study of racism helps us understand how White supremacy is continuously (re)produced through genocide, Indigenous displacement and erasure, exploitation of a racialized labor force, and appropriation of land for White capital accumulation at the expense of Black lives and other racialized bodies (Bonds & Inwood, 2016; McKay et al., 2020). As many social work programs have come to learn in recent times, they and the social work profession are not exempt from upholding White supremacy.

Historically, mainstream social work pedagogy, practices, and its epistemological stance has served to maintain White supremacy and uphold color-evasive racism (Aldana & Vazquez, 2020; Wright et al., 2021; Yearwood et al., 2021). Even with the National Association of Social Work's (NASW) professional Code of Ethics, whose latest updates to cultural competence standards mandate that "social workers must take action against oppression, racism, discrimination, and inequities, and acknowledge personal privilege" (NASW, 2021a), and a call to action against institutional racism (NASW, 2021b), social work education has yet to prepare social workers to address racism. Instead, notions about social justice in social work are primarily derived from Western philosophy and Eurocentric sociopolitical perspectives (Finn, 2016). Consequently, the training of social workers often neglects to prepare them to critically examine the role of racism in inhibiting human rights and an equitable society. Based on the sociopolitical climate in the U.S. and the state of social work education, there is a reemergence in the drive for social work to find theoretical frameworks that are anti-racist in nature.

With a few notable exceptions, in most schools of social work in the U.S., content on racism and racial equity is peripherally included as part of the Council of Social Work Education (CSWE) mandated diversity/anti-oppression courses. Operating within the country's dominant color-evasive racial ideology, the attention social work education has given to racism has been sporadic and inconsistent throughout its history. Dis/ability Critical Race Theory (DisCrit) notions of color-evasive racism expands upon the narrow and ableist conceptualizations of the inability to perceive race as "color-blindness" to further our understanding of how this racial ideology is an active avoidance and refusal to recognize racism (Annamma et al., 2017). Accordingly, color-evasive racial ideology can be understood as a "race-neutral" stance that avoids recognizing race and minimizes or disregards the role of racism in shaping inequality and intergroup relations (Bonilla-Silva, 2017; Henricks, 2018).

Liberal discourse in the U.S. after the Civil Rights Movement advanced a dominant color-evasive racial ideology that purported the misguided notion that ignoring race would ameliorate racism. Accordingly, social work has primarily relied on the model of cultural competence to address issues of diversity and difference, but scholars identify that this model falls short in more ways than one, including the reinforcement of color-evasive ideologies (Aldana & Vazquez, 2020; Stephens & Rock-Vanloo, 2022). For instance, Abrams and Moio (2009) argue that the cultural competency approach in social work education mainly focuses on individual attitudes and biases, promoting a color-evasive understanding of inequality that does

not prepare social workers to address institutional racism and its intersections with other forms of oppression. Adherence to a multicultural framework through the "cultural competence" conceptualization of practice limits one's structural analysis of racism. It does not reflect the life-long process of critical reflexivity required for liberatory cross-cultural work.

Social work education has evolved from a multicultural approach, which highlights the diversity within our client populations, to an anti-oppression framework that attends to issues of inequality across multiple markers of difference. The emphasis on cultural sensitivity and competence within multicultural perspectives in social work often served to satisfy requirements set forth by the CSWE (Abrams & Moio, 2009; Ortiz & Jani, 2010). While more attentive to the structural nature of inequality, the anti-oppression pedagogical approach in social work education has often minimized the centrality of racism in structuring inequality (Graham & Schiele, 2010). The longstanding anti-racism contributions of scholars of color to pedagogy, research, and practice have often been ignored or pushed to the margins in social work (Aldana & Vazquez, 2020; Murray-Lichtman et al., 2022). Accordingly, the current state of mainstream social work education has limited social workers' ability to engage in anti-racist practices.

We have all been exposed to the dominant color-evasive racial ideology that aims to socialize one to avoid noticing, talking about, and challenging the notions of race and racism in the U.S. Therefore, a fundamental problem for critical social work in the U.S. that aims to pursue social justice is eradicating its complicity in color-evasive racism. When a social worker perceives inequality, they may attribute social conditions to lack of employment or limited access to resources (Robinson, 2011) without a clear understanding of the structural nature of settler colonialism and White supremacy that excludes Black, Indigenous, and other racialized people of color from America's opportunity structure. Critical social work in the U.S. must enhance the ability of social workers to perceive, scrutinize, and challenge racial oppression. Thus, social work education needs to directly and intentionally teach future social workers how to identify and address manifestations of racism. Social work scholars suggest that critical race theory (CRT) provides a framework for social work that critically assesses the pervasive power of race and racism and calls for social workers to dismantle structural forms of racism (Nakaoka & Ortiz, 2018; Stephens & Rock-Vanloo, 2022).

Critical Race Theory

Critical Social Work aims to disrupt the status quo in part by countering to the color-evasive service-oriented approach predominant in our profession (Avila et al., 2020; Campbell & Baikie, 2012). Relatedly, a CRT-informed approach encourages social workers to provide more than "services," by attending to racism as a structural force shaping the lives of their clients and communities of practice. CRT is a dynamic theoretical framework that surfaced in the late 1970s as a critical response to the color-evasive justice pedagogy occurring in schools of law in the United States (Delgado & Stefancic, 2001). Its development within American legal scholarship and subsequent application in other disciplines and professions, such as the field of education and public health, makes it uniquely relevant for addressing racism in social work practice and policy (Aldana & Vazquez, 2020; Razack & Jeffery, 2002). Through its core tenets, CRT examines how race and its intersections with other markers of identity are social constructions that lay the groundwork for the systemic and institutional oppression of marginalized groups. It is therefore necessary to note that CRT is about a "race ***and***" structural analysis of intersectional oppression that limits social justice processes, practices, and outcomes. That is, intentionally

centering an analysis of racism, as one examines its intersections with other systems of dominance such as sexism, cis-heterosexism, classism, and nativism.

The interdisciplinary nature of CRT scholarship has enhanced its ability to examine how racism overlaps and reinforces other forms of oppression. An overview of CRT's genealogy depicts the ways that CRT—and its branches like TribalCrit, LatCrit, AsianCrit, DisCrit, QueerCrit, and WhiteCrit—have critiqued and expanded upon early theorizing about racism within a Black/White binary to explicate the intersections of racism with settler colonialism, cultural nationalism, cis-heteropatriarchy, ableism, and other forms of subjugation (Solórzano & Yosso, 2001). These branches do not oppose CRT or one another. Instead, they offer a constellation of critical perspectives that offer a complete portrayal of the patterns of racialization and the permanence of racism. Moreover, the education profession has advanced the conceptualization and praxis of critical race pedagogy in a way relevant to social work education. For instance, educational scholars have proposed a critical race pedagogical model that not only recognizes the pervasiveness of racism and settler colonialism in the U.S. but also centers the significance of cultural identity, intersectional analysis of oppression, development of reflexivity, and liberatory teaching practices (Jennings & Lynn, 2005), Accordingly, the integration of CRT in social work education will require intentional integration of CRT-related content and also continuous improvements of liberatory pedagogical strategies in and outside of the classroom (Aldana et al., in press).

In social work, scholarship on the relevance of CRT as a pedagogical tool has proliferated within the past decade (Abrams & Moio, 2009; Constance-Huggins, 2012; Ortiz & Jani, 2010). Now more than ever, we support the integration of CRT, and its branches, in social work education to address the limitations of the multicultural approach prevalent in the U.S. (Abrams & Moio, 2009; Aldana & Vazquez, 2020; Constance-Huggins, 2012; Ortiz & Jani, 2010). Though much of the literature advocated for its use for over a decade, empirical evidence of its actual implementation in social work education has proliferated more rapidly in recent years (Ashley & Paez, 2015; Avila et al., 2020; Duhaney et al., 2022; Einbinder, 2019; Murray-Litchtman et al., 2022). This paper aims to contribute to this growing body of literature by providing an illustrative example of the integration of CRT's conceptual underpinnings and tenets across a Master of Social Work (MSW) program curriculum.

Integration of CRT in a Master of Social Work Program

Before we discuss the integration of CRT into an MSW curriculum, we present a brief description of our positionality within social work education, the historical background of the university, and its contemporary educational context. I, Adriana Aldana, am a cisgender Chicana, associate professor of social work, the daughter of Mexican immigrants, and a *meztiza* descendent of Indigenous people and Spanish (White) settlers. It is important to note that critiques of mestizaje, as a colonial construct underscore how the dominant narrative about mestizaje as a nationalist ideology has served to minimize the role of race, racism, and White supremacy in Mexico and other Latin American countries and Caribbean islands. I disclose my mestiza identity not to perpetuate color-evasive conceptions of *latinidad*, but to acknowledge the liminality inherit in my racial-ethnic identity. I, Nicole Vazquez, come to this article at this moment as a cisgender, queer Afro-Latinx, critical race praxitioner (praxis practitioner) woman of Mexican American and Panamanian parents. I, Taylor Hosea, am a White, cisgender woman with a chronic autoimmune condition and a recent alumna of the MSW program. I am currently

an associate clinical social worker serving justice-impacted individuals. We have worked, taught, and learned at California State University Dominguez Hills (CSUDH), located in the home and land of the Tongva Nation.

We recognize that our campus, as a land-grant institution and part of the California public university system, was built on stolen Indigenous land. In 1965, the University first opened its doors in affluent Palos Verdes. However, following the Watts Rebellion and subsequent advocacy efforts by residents of color that highlighted institutional inequality in the area, the campus was relocated to Carson later that year (CSUDH, n.d.). Today, the University is a leading institution within the state in awarding degrees to African American students and is classified as a Hispanic Serving Institution. We are humbled to continue to grow in our relationship with this place and strive to engage in efforts towards decolonizing the academy and anti-racism in social work education.

Through the CRT lens, the MSW Program at CSUDH explicitly addresses how race and racism are embedded in our everyday lives. The program's emphasis on CRT enhances our ability to understand clients' circumstances through an analysis of the barriers of institutional racism and the intersections of multiple layers of privilege and oppression. The MSW Program is the only social work program that explicitly and intentionally integrated CRT throughout its curriculum since its founding in 2006. The MSW Program's student body typically consist of 90% Black, Indigenous, and People of Color (BIPOC). Hereafter, we use the acronym BIPOC to indicate any racialized people who experience systemic racism in the U.S., with particular attention to Black and Indigenous peoples, given their history of oppression and erasure in this country. Whenever appropriate, we will identify specific ethnic-racial groups.

Most of our students are born and raised in the geographic region surrounding the campus, which includes some of the most underserved urban neighborhoods in the Southern California region. The founding Department Chair, Dr. Larry Ortiz, recognized the opportunity to reimagine what an MSW program that predominantly serves BIPOC students can look like. The founding faculty had a passion and desire to center the curriculum on the systemic racism prevalent throughout U.S. history and its implications for and impact on social work (Nakaoka et al., 2019). CRT was therefore chosen as the theoretical foundation of the program, speaking directly to the histories and experiences of the student population and within the context of the region in which the University is located. Given its student population, the MSW Program aims to decenter whiteness by disrupting the "us" (White social worker) and "them" (clients/students of color) dichotomy common in diversity rhetoric to radically envision anti-racist social work from the perspective of practitioners and client population of color. CRT is infused throughout the program, from course readings, lectures, and assignments to guest speakers and practicum instructor training sessions.

The following section provides an overview of how CRT is integrated into the MSW explicit curriculum. We begin with an overview of the theory course that provides students with a foundational knowledge of the CRT tenets. We discuss the ways CRT informs class content and course design. Then, we describe examples of the infusion of the various tenets in other required courses to illustrate ways CRT complements and broadens the existing social work curriculum. Rather than describing how each tenet is integrated into every single course and all aspects of the curriculum, we offer select examples that define one or two tenets in the context of

the courses to highlight their application in social work and their relevance to specific social work education content areas.

Foundational Course: Critical Race Studies in Social Work Practice

MSW Program students take *Critical Race Studies in Social Work Practice* in their first semester. This course sets the foundation for the rest of the curriculum and introduces students to the following CRT tenets, which are based on programmatic priorities set from the inception of the program:

- Voices of color/counternarratives
- Race is a social construct
- Differential racialization
- Racism is ordinary
- Critique of liberalism
- Interest convergence
- Intersectionality

CRT has many tenets that are not written or discussed in a standardized way, which is by design, as CRT has historically resisted standardization. The MSW curriculum, therefore, covers the tenets often discussed across introductory CRT texts and those tenets our MSW program determined most relevant to social work. In addition, the title of the course purposefully used "studies" rather than "theory" to reflect the transdisciplinary scholarship from social science disciplines and other professional fields (e.g., public health, education) that have contributed to the ongoing development of CRT its branches (e.g., TribalCrit, DisCrit) and other related critical race frameworks. Accordingly, the course employs peer-review journal articles, podcasts, agency reports, and blogs further to contextualize the CRT tenets for social work students. Most course content, with more than 70% of course readings and materials, is by BIPOC authors, creators, or producers from multidisciplinary perspectives. The course textbook, *Racism in the United States: Implications for the Helping Professions* (Miller & Garran, 2017) provides a cohesive overview of the "web of institutional racism" and its significance for social workers and other related professions.

The course is grounded in the tenet of *Voices of Color*, or *Counternarratives*, which consciously moves away from dominant cultural narratives and legitimizes the knowledge and experience of communities of color (Delgado & Stefancic, 2001), thus decentering White supremacist culture and in turn the Eurocentric nature of social work pedagogy and practice. Moreover, storytelling methodology and narrative assignments in this course center students' personal stories as relevant and worthy, guiding them in making connections between theory and their lived experiences (for more instructional strategies, see Avila et al., 2020). As such, the fifteen-week course is structured in a way that asks students to engage in critical self-reflection about their race, ethnicity, and other salient social identities, make connections between their lived experiences and the theoretical concepts discussed in class, then apply a CRT lens to the analysis of social issues relevant to social work.

All the CRT tenets provide a guide for analyzing racism and social inequality across context and how they can be applied to social work. As one example, the tenet *Race is a Social Construction* (Delgado & Stefancic, 2001) provides a basic understanding of how racial

categories are not a biological reality but rather a result of intergroup relations and social thought. Introduced along with the idea of the cycle of socialization (Harro, 2000), the tenet's notions about social constructed nature of racial categorization helps surfaces students' own racial socialization and experiential knowledge. This early course discussions sets the stage for questioning our racialized experiences in the U.S., the implications for social work, and develops students' capacity to confront their complicity in maintaining system racial oppression as social work professionals.

The tenet *Differential Racialization* enables us to train social work students to apply a racial analysis to social inequality across groups. Building on the idea that race is a social construction, differential racialization affirms that various groups in the United States—Blacks, Latinx, Asian-Americans, Native Americans, and Muslims, for example—are racialized in specific ways throughout our history to uphold the interest of White supremacy (Delgado & Stefancic, 2001). Racialization is the process of assigning racial meaning to bodies, groups, or interactions that may factor in physical features and cultural markers, such as language, clothing, and beliefs (Selod, 2014). Differential racialization moves beyond the multicultural approach that focuses on teaching social work students to "appreciate diversity," and learn about "cultural differences" to better examine the ways that the social construction of race systemically disenfranchises, dehumanizes, and oppresses distinct social groups racialized as "other" and "less than" in the U.S.

One class activity illustrates how differential racialization can be applied to understand the effects of racism on communities of color across time and space. Working in groups, students examine how slavery, boarding schools for Indigenous children, the war on drugs and mass incarceration, and draconian immigration policies have been used to separate families over time, giving them a deeper understanding of U.S. history (Murray-Lichtman et al., 2022). We discuss how these racially discriminatory policies and practices often result in social issues of concern to social workers, such as intergenerational trauma and mental health disparities. Deeper still, we unpack the role of social workers in implementing these racially biased policies and practices. This activity invites all students to interrogate and challenge their participation in the social structures that oppress others, critically self-reflecting on the complexities of implicit bias, privilege, and internalized racial oppression (Pyke, 2010).

Teaching and learning about differential racialization, along with the rest of the tenets in the Critical Race Studies course, does not involve learning about the "other" but rather exploring one's positionality, or social location, within the web of institutional racism. Developing critical self-reflexivity skills that attend to one's positionality is essential to engaging in critical social work practice that attends to power dynamics that derive from our privileged group memberships as well as those social identities targeted by systems of oppression. Cultivating critical self-reflection of one's social location in a racialized society among faculty and students aligns with critical race pedagogy attention to reflexivity (Jennings & Lynn, 2005). As social workers, critical race reflexivity enables us to critically examine our privileged position(s), as well as social locations of solidarity, in relation to those we serve and work with to dismantle systemic oppression (Aldana et al., in press). Critical racial reflexivity about one's positionality, informed by CRT, also allows social workers to interrogate dominant narratives and socialization that have informed their attitudes, beliefs, and worldview. In turn, critical awareness of positionality and worldviews shape our orientation to racial justice and social work practice.

Human Behavior in the Social Environment (HBSE) Courses

The integration of CRT throughout the curriculum reinforces an analytic lens that centers on the role of racism in creating inequality to help students contextualize the lived experience of racialized groups. CRT is concurrently used with other multidisciplinary HBSE frameworks as well. The tenet *Racism is Ordinary*, which explains how racism is a systemic form of oppression pervasive in all aspects of society that can be difficult to perceive at times, is particularly useful in examining how White supremacy and racial oppression manifest at the micro-, mezzo-, and macro-systems. What is more, using a CRT lens provides students with an analytic tool to assess and critique the effectiveness of other HBSE frameworks in addressing the role of race and racism in explaining the human condition and social contexts of diverse populations.

Critical race theorist Tara Yosso (2005) provides a strengths-based approach to systems theory and the person-in-environment perspective by introducing the idea of community cultural wealth as an alternative to the Eurocentric definition of social capital. Highlighting the concept of community cultural wealth within HBSE courses shifts the deficit-based mainstream understanding of capital and reframes it to highlight the skills, abilities, and knowledge created and used by people of color to thrive in a world that was not created with them in mind. The integration of CRT into HBSE courses not only allows students to think more critically about the institutional and structural ways racism shapes the social environment but also helps social work students envision themselves and the communities they work with as capable of creating social change.

Social Welfare Policy Courses

In our policy course, we use CRT's *Critique of Liberalism* to help students find and critically examine the subtle color-evasive attitudes and coded language inherent in major U.S. social welfare policies. White supremacy is entrenched in the liberal Calvinistic ideals of rugged individualism, meritocracy, and hard work ethic reinforced through settler colonialism and racial capitalism (Aldana & Vazquez, 2020). Critique of liberalism questions the "pull yourself up by your bootstraps/equal playing field" liberal ideology of meritocracy so profoundly embedded in American life that places responsibility on the individual for their outcome in life (Blau & Abramovitz, 2010), rather than analyzing systems that create and perpetuate inequity. Liberal ideology is exemplified in The Personal Responsibility and Work Opportunity Reconciliation Act of 1996 (PRWORA). PRWORA is the most recent large-scale welfare reform act that "end(ed) welfare as we know it and transform(ed) our broken welfare system by promoting the fundamental values of work, responsibility, and family (Clinton, 1996)."

Students learn to dissect the policy, starting with the name of the legislation itself, which signals a focus on the individual, a nod to the settler colonial protestant values of hard work and personal responsibility. Students are first exposed to the role of settler colonialism—as a political and economic structure of White supremacy—in reinforcing the socialization and internalization of racial capitalist meritocratic values in the form "hard work ethics" that undermine the role of rest as a radical act of self-care in the *Critical Race Studies in Social Work* course (for a pedagogical example see Aldana, 2022). Applying the critique of liberalism tenet in policy courses reinforces their learning of this CRT tenet. It enhances their ability to think critically about the role of White supremacy in color-evasive, liberal policies. Further, course discussions analyze how coded language and racial stereotypes like "welfare queens" were used as tactics to

set the stage for public and political support for the legislation, resulting in means-tested assistance being mainly associated with people of color.

The tenet of *Interest Convergence* is another CRT tenet that is useful tool for social workers to examine the pervasiveness of color-evasive racial ideology present in policy and the legislative process (Daftary et al., 2021). Interest convergence suggests that the civil, legal, and social gains for marginalized groups occur when such social change coincides with the interest of the dominant group (Bell, 1980; Delgado & Stefancic, 2017). Applying this tenet to social work practice is particularly relevant to teaching social work students how to engage in policy practice through an anti-racist lens. As a tool of critical analysis, social work students learn to examine how policy can directly or indirectly (through unintended consequences) benefit the dominant, White population. CRT-informed analysis of policy in general enables social workers to demonstrate and challenge the continuing influence of racial oppression in policymaking.

Research Methods Courses

The Council of Social Work Education's (CSWE, 2022) most recent draft of the Educational Policy and Accreditation Standards now expects social workers to "use ethical, culturally informed, and anti-racist and anti-oppressive approaches to conducting research and building knowledge" (p. 5). For the first time in our profession's history, the CSWE has directly and explicitly called for the critique of racial bias in practice-informed research and research-informed practice. Again, we find that integrating CRT into research methods courses have enabled our program to be prepared to meet this accreditation standard. In the generalist-level research course, students learn to understand how engagement with or utilization of research without integrating a CRT lens may perpetuate color-evasive racism. For instance, in teaching basic research concepts, such as measurement, participant recruitment, and data analysis, a CRT analysis helps students problematize White colonial practices within the research process.

The interconnectedness of White supremacy and settler colonialism is also evident in epistemic racism. Research, as a form of knowledge production and dissemination, contains racialized power dynamics (Collins, 1990). The "epistemic violence" in White colonial epistemologies has aimed to eradicate cultural values, practices, and ways of knowing not derived from Western European epistemologies (Vázquez, 2011; Spivak, 1988). The integration of CRT in social work education and research training, enables students to consider critical inquiry approaches appropriate for a racialized society (Daftary, 2020). Intellectual engagement with CRT branches such as TribalCrit (Brayboy, 2005) and LatCrit (Kiehne, 2016) also helps students learn how to scrutinize dominant research paradigms that erase and devalue multiple ways of knowing and Indigenous wisdom in the name of "rigor." In social work, for example, the integration of a LatCrit perspective—which centers a critique of value-neutrality in dominant methods of inquiry, differential racialization within settler colonialism, and academic activism—has the potential to deconstruct and decolonize social work epistemology (Nakaoka et al., in press). In general, students learn that the integration of CRT into social work research provides a framework that adheres to our social work values and ethics.

Critical race methodology aims to promote our understanding of racism by elevating situated knowledge, multiple ways of knowing, and creative strategies for participatory research methods (Aldana & Richards-Schuster, 2021). Accordingly, the MSW's advanced research

curriculum leverage the voices of color/counternarrative tenet and CRT's commitment to social action to teach students about community-based participatory action research (CBPR). The students work in groups throughout the semester to conceptualize and propose a CBPR study informed by CRT to empower their population of interest in creating change through collaborative inquiry. This research proposal assignment requires students to articulate how CRT informs every facet of research. Having learned to value multiple ways of knowing (e.g., storytelling, narrative inquiry, etc.) that are often ignored or dismissed by positivistic approaches to social science in previous courses, the advanced research methods course also allows students to envision liberatory research projects that center the lived experience of racialized and marginalized people.

Practice Courses

Direct practice work with individuals, families, and communities is delivered through the lens of understanding the racist and oppressive policies that helped to create**,** then perpetuate oppressive and unequal opportunity structures for service users. CRT provides a theoretical foundation that allows us to train practitioners to understand that the conditions that clients of color present before the social worker may have more to do with racist institutions and systems than with the client themselves. In practice courses, students are expected to use a CRT perspective to inform their assessment of clients, engagement with diverse communities, and intervention approaches.

C*ritique of Liberalism* can be employed, for instance, in understanding a client's behavior and health outcomes. Bonilla-Silva (2017) explains "abstract liberalism" as the most difficult color-evasive ideological frame to understand because it is not explicitly about race. Under this liberal frame, which relies on notions of equal opportunity and meritocracy, one interprets racial disparities because of individuals' choices rather than institutional or structural barriers that disproportionately exclude and target people of color. We, therefore, guide students in employing a CRT lens to identify the social determinants of health in a systems theory approach to social work practice. For example, whereas one social worker might attribute a client's non-compliance to seek medical treatment to individual choice (Robinson, 2011), we discuss with students the systemic barriers to treatment, such as the lack of accessible healthcare options in racially and economically segregated communities as a reason for non-compliance.

Further, it is known that health outcomes such as high blood pressure, diabetes, and asthma disproportionately impact people of color (National Center for Health Statistics, 2016; Oraka et al., 2013; Smedley et al., 2003; Yoon et al., 2012; Zhang et al., 2009). As CRT-informed social workers, our students learn to apply an intersectional lens to fully understand that these conditions are not due to poor choices but the impact of intersecting structural forces. *Intersectionality*, both a CRT tenet and a stand-alone theoretical perspective, explicates the interconnected nature of multiple systems of oppression (Collins, 1990; Crenshaw, 1989). Applying an intersectional lens, students are taught to examine how settler colonialism, White supremacy, cis-heteropatriarchy, capitalism, and other forms of oppression shape individuals' lives in communities that are affected by racial and economic segregation, which in turn creates a food apartheid where grocery stores that offer fresh fruits and vegetables are vastly outnumbered by liquor stores and fast-food restaurants that offer less expensive, unhealthy options for feeding families on a limited budget. Additionally, government policies such as eminent domain create freeways that cut through neighborhoods (Avila, 2004; Laslett, 2015). Moreover, factories and

refineries often find their way into these same hyper-segregated communities, thus creating greater levels of pollution that cause asthma and other health disparities (Williams & Collins, 2001).

Intersectionality, as a pedagogical practice, offers an analytical tool for anti-oppressive and reflexive social work (Mattsson, 2014). Rather than operating from an individualistic liberal framework that places the full burden of improving health outcomes solely on the individual, teaching students to apply an intersectional CRT framework helps them link racism with economic and other forms of social inequality and structural determinants of health and wellbeing. An intersectional approach is essential to anti-racist social work practice. Thus, our MSW students learn to assess and approach individual client situations from a critical and systems-level perspective. Social work practice is therefore employed with a contextual and structural lens in addition to a cultural lens.

Finally, studies show that social workers still hold biased perceptions of clients of color and engage in biased practice behaviors (Staudt, 2011). These biases can be attributed to color-evasive racial ideology, which overlooks the role of race in structuring social inequality in the U.S. (Bonilla-Silva, 2017; Henricks, 2018). This color-evasive racial ideology follows the "objectivity" in which client assessment has historically been taught, for example. Our colleague Chun Wetterau (2015) shares a case study that outlines the praxis of CRT, providing its tenets as frameworks for providing a contextually competent assessment when completing an assessment with an immigrant Hmong family. This article offers an alternative to the dominant culture's standards of appropriate and acceptable family dynamics and ways of living. Chun Wetterau's work is one of the few that explicitly ties CRT's tenets to direct social work practice, modeling critical race social work praxis for students and practitioners alike.

Conclusion

CRT's commitment to social justice (Crenshaw, 1998) provides a framework for not only understanding the system and ideologies embedded in policies but changing them as well. Social work educators suggest restructuring the curriculum and adopting an infusion style approach in anti-oppressive and anti-racist pedagogy so that students are better equipped to apply theory to practice (Constance-Huggins et al., 2020; Franco, 2020; Ladhani & Sitter, 2020; Wagaman et al., 2019). The integration of CRT content across the curriculum helps us expose the explicit and implicit color-evasive rhetoric in our society and to call out racism and its real-life consequences in social work practice for what they are. It moves away from cultural competence and aspirations to be part of a "helping profession." The notability of critical race social work praxis, therefore, is that it can be applied both at the clinical and policy levels.

The notions of race and its oppressive manifestations through racism and intersections with multiple forms of subjugation are ever-changing and contextual. Therefore, teaching social workers how to critically interrogate and address White supremacy for themselves is necessary. The history of mainstream social work education has shown us that teaching about cultural differences or addressing racism at the margins of anti-oppression pedagogy is not enough (Aldana & Vazquez, 2020; Ladhani & Sitter, 2020). Social workers need the knowledge and skills to assess how racism is ordinary, and its intersectional impacts will manifest differently in various practice contexts. For us, through the integration of its tenets throughout the curriculum,

CRT offers a variety of analytic tools for the structural analysis of inequality through multiple theoretical angles, as well as fostering critical self-reflexivity.

Because race and racism are socially constructed and ever-changing, anti-racism should also constantly evolve (Gillborn, 2016). CRT is not flawless, and though it resonates with social work students and is endorsed by social work educators, there is a lack of empirical research regarding CRT's application to social work praxis. CRT, although perceived as valuable, some students report is difficult for them to apply to practices outside of clinical assessments (Einbinder, 2019). It is a relatively new social work perspective, and with ongoing scholarship, we will inevitably find its limitations and shortcomings. Nevertheless, its absence from social work education should be noted and critiqued.

The MSW Program's critical race curriculum continues to be refined through student feedback, faculty analysis, and collaboration with other like-minded scholars and programs. Reflecting on the evolution of the MSW program and its integration of CRT since its founding in 2006 continues to offer multiple lessons for advancing critical race pedagogy in social work. The lessons we have learned along the way suggest that critical race pedagogy requires the decentering of dominant Eurocentric perspectives across the MSW curriculum, disrupting White supremacy cultural characteristics embedded within the implicit curriculum (e.g., learning environment, organizational culture), and student-centered pedagogy that prepares students for race-conscious practice (Aldana et al., in press). Moving away from multiculturalism towards a CRT-informed approach in social work education at all levels of an MSW program requires a slow and intentional process that builds capacity for trust building across differences, engaging multiple stakeholders (students, faculty, staff), and leveraging internal/external institutional support (Polk et al., 2021). Thus, meaningful integration of CRT and critical race pedagogy in social work education involves an iterative process of countering White hegemony, negotiating power at multiple levels, and critical self-reflectivity.

It is crucial to engage in the difficult work of critical self-reflexivity continuously. In an editorial piece underscoring the uncomfortable but necessary application of CRT in social work, Crewe (2020, p. 416) explains, "when we challenge the practices that we have so willingly embraced, we recognize our part of the problem...moving to becoming part of the solution begins with reckoning with our roles in carrying out the 'master's' plans." Indeed, teaching and learning about race and racism through a CRT lens is often uncomfortable for educators and students. In addition to their comfort level, faculty members' racial identity, limited formal preparation to teach race-based concepts, and lack of teaching about race skills are barriers to integrating antiracist course content (Perez, 2020). Student narratives suggest that as a critical race pedagogy tool, unsettling reflexivity is essential to interrogating one's positionalities and examining more critically dominant discourses, structures, and the cultural norms of social work education (Tang Yan et al., 2022). In short, disrupting White supremacy in social work education requires courage.

Critical race pedagogy invites us as social workers to courageously analyze our positionality in a settler-colonial society and to be honest with ourselves about whether and how we uphold White supremacy in all its forms. After engaging in the challenging task of critical self-reflexivity and continuous participation in difficult but courageous conversations about racism in our organizations to support each other, we begin to witness the strides made toward

transformational systemic change. We encourage social work students, educators, and practitioners to engage in an ongoing practice of critical self-reflection and the collective transformative engagement necessary for effective anti-racist social work practice. As social workers, our lifetime work should aim for racial justice, and CRT is one of the many theoretical tools that may inform our liberatory praxis.

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